towards the police party blocking the road, who returned fire. Pandey was injured. One of the occupants of the jeep, Hardev Singh Chhina, was killed, and three others were injured. The driver of the jeep, Gursant Singh, reversed the vehicle and took the dead body to Guru Nanak Niwas. Gursant narrated the incident to Bhindranwale, who issued a statement accusing the police of murdering one of his associates in cold blood. Atwal's source was soon identified and the nature of his connection with Atwal extracted from him. His mutilated body was found later outside Guru Nanak Niwas. As a result, Atwal became a marked man on Bhindranwale's hit list. [6]

On 25 April 1983, Atwal entered the Golden Temple complex through the Clock Tower entrance at around 10 a.m. Like any other Sikh, he undertook the parikrama of the sacred sarovar (tank) before paying homage to the Guru Granth Sahib in Darbar Sahib. He then came out, received prasad and walked towards the Clock Tower side exit. Holding the prasad, he climbed the thirteen marble steps and was about to leave the complex when he was shot from behind. Riddled with seven bullets, Atwal died on the spot and his body lay there in broad daylight in full view of a large number of people. Policemen at a nearby post remained mute witness to their senior officer's murder, despite knowing that the person responsible for it was hiding a short distance away at Guru Nanak Niwas.

Reportedly, Brigadier Tejinder Singh Grewal, a close relation of Atwal's, and his friend Jarnail Singh Chahal, an IPS officer of the Punjab cadre, had asked Atwal to come to Amritsar on 25 April for discussions on an important matter. Grewal was at that time posted at the army headquarters in New Delhi. Chahal was the person who had negotiated Bhindranwale's surrender at Chowk Mehta in 1981. According to the slain DIG's family, Atwal initially resisted going to Amritsar but was persuaded by the two officials over the telephone. The three had a long discussion before Atwal went into the Golden Temple.

Both Grewal and Chahal had been hobnobbing with Longowal and Bhindranwale for some time. [7] In fact, at the precise moment that Atwal was gunned down, Chahal was alone with Longowal and Grewal was also in the vicinity. Rather than go to the scene of crime, where Atwal's body lay unclaimed, both Grewal and Chahal